Cuba's delegation. When Magín applied for NGO status under Cuban law in 1996, the Party's Central Committee refused, as if, long-time Revolution supporter Margaret Randall suggested, "they were afraid these women might be duped into making contacts or doing work which inadvertently played into the enemy's hands." Randall wrote acerbically that "trusting the insights and intelligence of its own best citizens rather than relying on such insulting excuses might have pushed true revolution forward."[50]

The climate for debate and criticism in Cuba was not improved by President Clinton's vaunted "Track Two" policy for eliminating the Castro government. The first track was the longstanding negative policy of opposing the Revolution. Track Two would add a positive side of trying to promote U.S. goals by reaching out to potential or actual Cuban dissidents, trying to foster academic and other non-governmental contacts that would lure Cubans into the U.S. or "pro-democracy" camp. While the Cuban government welcomed the increased travel to Cuba that Track Two engendered – it complemented Cuba's own strategy of increasing tourism and fostering opposition to U.S. policies among those who had traveled to the island – Track Two's focus on cultivating dissidence from within only increased the government's suspicion of Cubans who seemed too close to foreigners.

Some leading intellectuals affiliated to the Party challenged Raúl's 1996 speech by speaking out in defense of academic freedom and critical thought. Abel Prieto, the President of Cuba's Artists and Writers Union (UNEAC) and a Politburo member, announced that "critical art" is "indispensable" for the Revolution, and characterized Raúl's speech as a "self-criticism" since it was directed at Party organs. "There will be no new censorship, nor will we return to the 1970s with their socialist realism, nor witch-hunts" Prieto announced. "Critical art and political debate are indispensable to maintain the cohesion of Cuban intellectuals around the revolution" he continued.[51]

Alfredo Guevara, the head of Cuba's film institute (ICAIC), also implicitly responded to Raúl's speech in his eulogy of Tomás Gutiérrez Alea, the director of "Strawberry and Chocolate" – a film that explicitly criticized the closed intellectual atmosphere of the 1970s. "He was a